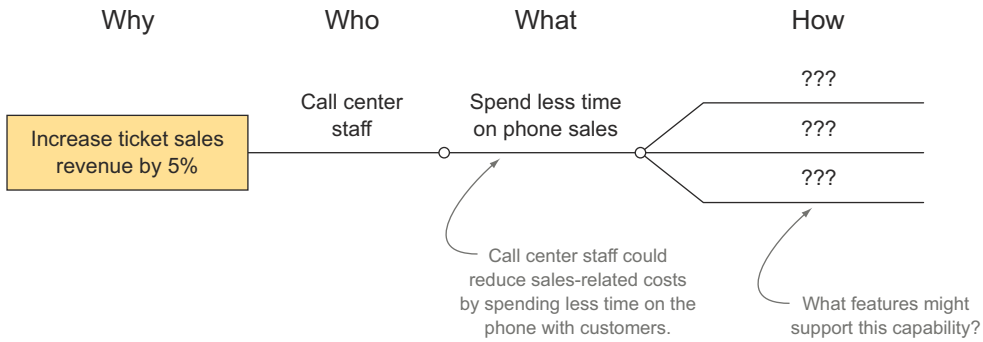


Figure 4.6 What features would support this capability?

If you're new to all this, the "in order to ... as a ... I want" format will help you stay focused on the business goals, but both forms are valid, and they convey essentially the same information. Experienced practitioners will be able to produce high-quality and meaningful definitions in both formats.

Ultimately, there's no right or wrong way to describe a feature, and no standard canonical format that you must use, though it's nice to agree on a consistent format within a team or project.

EXERCISE 4.1 Look at the impact map in figure 4.6. You want to give call center staff the capability to sell tickets more quickly over the phone. Define some features that would help support this capability.

4.1.2 Features can be broken down into more manageable chunks

When you describe a feature, you need to think in terms of functionality that delivers some useful capability to the end user. When you come to building and delivering a feature, you'll often need to break the feature down into smaller, more manageable pieces. You may or may not be able to deliver the whole feature in one iteration.

You can break features down further as you explore the best way to deliver a particular capability, using what's effectively a form of functional decomposition. In an Agile project, when you've broken the features down into chunks small enough to build within a single iteration, you can call the chunks "user stories." As you can see in figure 4.7, it's common to need more than one level of decomposition to get from a real-world feature to a reasonable-sized user story.

Knowing when the decomposed chunks are no longer features is a little subjective and varies from project to project. As we discussed earlier, a feature is something that users can test and use in isolation. A feature can deliver business value in itself; once a feature is completed, you could theoretically deploy it into production immediately, without having to wait for any other features to be finished first. Let's look at some examples: